AI Agent Skills and MCP: Building the Right AI Agent Pattern

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Chapter 4: Combining Agent Skills and MCP

Adding Skills to an MCP-Powered Agent

Bring back the launch-risk-review Skill and teach it where to find live data

In Chapter 2 the agent had know-how but no access. In Chapter 3 it had access but no know-how. In this video you combine them: the `launch-risk-review` Skill comes back, and you add one section that tells it how to gather live data through the `orbit` MCP server.

Before you start

You need the `orbit` server connected and the Skill parked, as at the end of Chapter 3. If you're not sure, run this from the folder that contains `orbit-launch` and `solutions`:

```
node solutions/catch-up.mjs 03_01
```

Then make sure the company data is clean. From a terminal in `orbit-backend`, run:

```
npm run reset
```

Step 1: Bring the Skill back

Move the Skill from `parked-skills` back into `.claude/skills`, then delete the empty `parked-skills` folder. From a terminal in `orbit-launch`, on macOS or Linux:

```
mv parked-skills/launch-risk-review .claude/skills/
rmdir parked-skills
```

On Windows (PowerShell):

```
Move-Item parked-skills\launch-risk-review .claude\skills\
Remove-Item parked-skills
```

Step 2: Teach the Skill where to look

Open `.claude/skills/launch-risk-review/SKILL.md`. After the line that starts with "Use this Skill to find risks," and before `## Process`, add this section:

```
## Gather the information
```

```
If the `orbit` MCP server is available, use it as the source of truth:

1. Call `get_project` for the launch date and the review date.
2. Call `list_milestones` to see which milestones are at risk or not
started.
3. Call `list_tasks` with `status: "blocked"`, then with `unassigned_only:
true`. Read the notes on every task you return.
4. Call `search_tickets` with `status: "open"` and `min_days_open: 7`,
then with `status: "open"` and `priority: "P1"`.

If the user also provides documents (status updates, notes, emails), use
them for context, but treat live data as more current.

If the `orbit` server isn't available, review only the documents provided
and say in the report that the data is a snapshot.
```

Don’t change anything else. The process, the rules, `rubric.md`, and `report-template.md` all stay exactly as they were in Chapter 2.

This section does three jobs:

- **It says where to look.** It names the tools and the filters to use, so the agent gathers the same data every time instead of improvising its own plan.
- **It sets source priority.** If someone also pastes a document, live data wins when the two disagree.
- **It falls back gracefully.** If the server isn’t available, the Skill still works on documents, the way it did in Chapter 2, and says that it’s working from a snapshot.

Step 3: Confirm the agent has both

Start a new Claude Code session in `orbit-launch`. Then check both pieces:

1. Type `/mcp` and confirm that `orbit` is connected.
2. Ask `What skills can you use?` and confirm that `launch-risk-review` appears.

Step 4: Run the review

Send:

```
Do this week’s launch review.
```

No file reference, no rules, no format. Approve the `orbit` tool calls as they appear. They all read data.

Step 5: Check the result against the rubric

Check the result:

- **Tool calls follow the Skill.** `get_project`, `list_milestones`, `list_tasks` for blocked tasks and then unassigned tasks, and `search_tickets` for old open tickets and then open P1 tickets.

- **The report uses the template.** The same heading, an Overall status line, the same five columns, and a Missing information section.
- **Overall status: Off track.**
- **High:** the PayGate slip (T-104), the unowned pen test booking (T-117), and the duplicate charges (TCK-1987, TCK-1992, TCK-2003, TCK-2010).
- **Medium:** the onboarding docs (T-121).
- **Low:** CSV export (TCK-2007) and dashboard speed (TCK-1999).
- **Left out:** the typo (TCK-2005), the dark mode request (TCK-2012), the closed ticket (TCK-1950), and the ticket waiting on the customer (TCK-2016).

Look at the duplicate charges in particular. In Chapter 2, the Skill could only rate them Medium, because the documents didn't include priorities. Now the agent can see four P1 tickets, each open more than 7 days, so the rubric's systemic issue rule applies and the risk is High. The rule didn't change. The evidence did.

Step 6: Run it once more

Type `/clear` and send the same request again:

```
Do this week's launch review.
```

Compare the two reports. The structure, the severity ratings, and the items left out should match. That's the consistency the MCP-only runs in video 03_04 didn't have, now on live data.

How the work is divided

- **The Skill decides when it applies,** through its description.
- **The Skill decides what to fetch,** through the Gather the information section.
- **MCP fetches it,** from Orbit Labs' systems.
- **The Skill judges it and writes the report,** through the rubric and the template.

Knowing where to look is part of knowing how to do the job, so it belongs in the Skill. The server stays generic: it exposes the tracker and the support desk, not "the launch review." If Orbit Labs moved its tickets to a different system, you would point this one section at a different server, and the rubric and template wouldn't change.

If you get stuck

From the folder that contains `orbit-launch` and `solutions`, run:

```
node solutions/catch-up.mjs 04_01
```

This moves the Skill back and writes the updated `SKILL.md`. Start a new Claude Code session afterward.